TAFS MUN

BACKGROUND GUIDE: UNGA-SOCHUM

AGENDA: *'ASSISTANCE TO THE SURVIVORS OF THE RWANDAN GENOCIDE'*

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INTRODUCTION

This background guide will firstly trace the origins of the Rwandan genocide, after which it shall highlight the important outcomes and effects of the same on the world at large. The subsequent topics will deal with individual cases of survivors and their account of the events of 1994. The intention of this background guide is to ensure that every delegate at least has a basic idea of what the agenda for discussion is as well as give them an insight into the actual problems faced today. The background guide shall also try and trace out a few topics that need to be addressed immediately as a guide for delegates to streamline their research. This however shall at no point in time act as a limiting factor, and delegates are encouraged to research exhaustively on every perceivable topic related to the agenda.

The 1994 genocide left a huge scar on the economy and society of the Rwandan people. It was an unprecedented mass-murder which left the country reeling in poverty and social and political unrest. The genocide had a ripple effect on the surrounding areas with the influx of refugees and subsequent armed attacks. It adversely affected a large area of the African continent and its repercussions can be felt till date. This committee shall aim to determine the nature and scope of the problem at hand and subsequently assess the possible solutions to address the same.

The global community, during the genocide, collectively turned a blind eye toward the slaughter of several thousands of innocent Tutsi and moderate Hutu people. The Rwandan Genocide revealed the governments of the world's ignorance and apathy, as well as their continuing selfishness and refusal to take blame.

Today several thousands of genocide survivors exist as refugees in surrounding countries as well as in Rwanda, in the worst of conditions. Systematically removed from their homeland, they face certain serious economic, social and health related problems. This assembly shall aim to address these problems and attempt to pass a resolution assisting said survivors of the 1994 Genocide.

HISTORY

On April 6 1994, preceding the death of president Juvenal Habyarimana, the state of Rwanda was launched into turmoil as genocides claimed the lives of at least half a million of its people (Seltzer in Des Forges, 1999, pp. 17). Initiated by the Hutu political elite and its military support, their prime targets were the Tutsi, as well as Hutu moderates. Many have purported "ethnic hatred" as the cause of the Rwanda Genocide and while an ethnic divide was indeed present in Rwanda around the time of the conflict, the reasons for the genocide are multiple and far more complex.

In analysing the Rwanda Genocide as an ethnic conflict it is essential that ethnicity be examined as it influenced and was influenced by economic, political and social factors. The challenge for defining the violence in Rwanda as an ethnic conflict is that while, on the one hand, the atrocities were a clear cut case of genocide, committed with "the criminal intent to destroy or to cripple permanently a human group" (Lemkin, 1947), the lines along which the victims were grouped were not just ethnic but also political.

For centuries, the Hutu and Tutsi in Rwanda have spoken a common language, believed in the same religion and lived in unison, in the same areas. Through intermarriage, Hutus have been able to become hereditary Tutsis and Tutsis have been able to become hereditary Hutus. Prior to Rwanda's colonization, the Tutsi and Hutu were characterized by an occupational distinction. Hutus were mainly cultivators and known as the "masses" in comparison to the Tutsis who were predominantly herdsmen and therefor considered the "elite" (Gourevitch, 1998; Human Rights Watch, 2006). Over time, the titles affiliated with each ethnic group became embedded in their social status and while both were aware of their overlying differences in class, this distinction only became a source of resentment when it was defined by an according level of power

The first signs of preferential treatment occurred in 1860 with the rise of the Tutsi king, Kigeri Rwabugiri, and the institution of a hierarchical administration in Rwanda. This event arguably created a division that favoured Tutsi in the upper crust of the hierarchy and subsequently limited Hutu political involvement to the lower ranks.

In 1959, the Hutu revolted against the Tutsi elite and established the first republic, simultaneously killing twenty thousand Tutsi and forcing an additional three-hundred thousand into exile (Human Rights Watch, 2006, pp.3). The degree of violence that Hutu revolutionaries exerted clearly demonstrated the animosity that had developed toward all Tutsi, not just the elite. As Rwanda gained independence, Tutsi refugees that had fled in preceding years, began retaliating with armed attacks which in turn prompted further Hutu aggression against innocent Tutsi civilians that were not members of the elite nor refugees that had taken part in the violent attacks (Barnett, 2002). In 1973, Rwanda witnessed yet another over political overthrow, but this time it was Juvenal Habyarimana and his Hutu regime (the MRND) that overpowered the Hutu leaders of the first republic in order to establish the second one (Human Rights Watch, 2006, pp.4). The significance of this event is that it illustrates that boundaries also existed within "ethnic groups" that divided members, in this particular instance, along political lines.

The Rwanda Patriotic Front (RPF) consisted mostly of Tutsi who had been living in exile since their escape from the 1959-1963 revolution. Their retreat to Rwanda in 1990 was an effort to allow the permanent return of Tutsi refugees and to eventually overthrow the Habyarimana regime (Human Rights Watch, 2006, pp. 4). While Rwanda had been in a violent state since the Hutu revolution in 1959, the RPF's attack in 1990 marked the beginning of a civil war. The conflict between the Hutu-dominated government and the Tutsi-dominated rebels continued through August 1993, when both parties signed the Arusha Peace Agreement, which "called for a democratically elected government and provided for the establishment of a broad-based transitional Government until the elections, in addition to repatriation of refugees and integration of the armed forces of the two sides" (Department of Public Information, United Nations, 1996; Straus, 2006, pp. 24). The stipulations of the peace agreement signified an end to the ruling elite's political monopoly, however with the dismal state of Rwanda's economy, Habyarimana had no choice but to concede to pressures by international donors and supporters (i.e. France) to allow the institution of multiple political parties (Human Rights Watch, 2006, pp.4). Ultimately, however, the conditions of the agreement were not upheld, as Hutu political parties such as the CDR and the MRND along with their militias and supporters refused to relinquish power. The creation and implementation of a transitional government (BBTG)

was repeatedly stalled and ultimately never established. Rather than move towards the creation of peace and unity, preparations for the "self-defence" program that had been initiated in response to the RPF's first attack in 1990 continued.

The Genocide

On April 6,1994, the crash of president Habyarimana's plane, widely rumoured to have been caused by the RPF, set the genocides in motion. "The crash acted like a signal; forty eight minutes later, the Presidential Guard erected the first road blocks and were immediately joined by the Interhamwe. Shortly afterward, the conspirators fanned out around the city, picking up and murdering leading Tutsi and moderate Hutu politicians, and evacuating MRND officials and their families to a camp where they would be safe" (Barnett, 2002, pp.98). The massacres ensued for a hundred days and were finally ended on 18 July 1994, when the RPF had seized almost complete control of Rwanda and declared a unilateral cease-fire (Barnett, 2002, 187).

While media sources regard the 1994 genocides as just another episode in a long, historic line of ethnic feuding, the reality is that the brutal assassinations of more than half a million people did not result from a widespread "ancient hatred" among the Hutu people, but rather a strategic plan of "self-defence" that mobilized ordinary civilians into ruthless killers. "For three and a half years, this [Hutu] elite worked to redefine the population of Rwanda into 'Rwandans,' meaning those who backed the president, and the "*ibyitso*" or "accomplices of the enemy," meaning the Tutsi minority and Hutu opposed to him" (Des Forges, 1999, pp.8).

Ultimately, the Hutu elite initiated the genocides to maintain political control by wiping out their competition. By employing "ethnic norms" and a system of punishments and rewards, the Hutu elite managed to gain supporters that joined the genocides in some instances with enthusiasm and in others with little choice.

The genocide itself occurred in a quick, planned fashion. In August 1993, General Roméo Dallaire, UN Force Commander, took his first African command as head of UNAMIR with 2500 lightly-armed Belgian and Ghanan troops. By March 1994, several Rwandan political and military figures had come to the United Nations trying to explain the precarious nature of the Rwandan peace-situation. On April 6, 1994 at 8:30 PM huge explosions were heard

from the Kigali airport. The Hutu presidential plane carrying President Habyarimana returning from Tanzania after signing the Peace Accord had been shot down by a missile. At the time it was disputed whether the Rwandan Patriotic Front or the President's own party had shot down the plane. Recent evidence suggests that the crash was caused by a land based missile from a Rwandan military base under the control of the Hutu government. The Hutu extremists therefore feared that the Peace Accord signed by the president did not provide them with enough control of the country and therefore had him publicly murdered "by the Tutsis cockroaches" to plunge the country into chaos. Over the night of April 9, 1994, 1000 French and Belgian paratroopers seized Kigali airport, independent of the United Nations. These 1000 troops commanded the airport and efficiently infiltrated the country to remove stranded Western citizens while leaving every single African behind. This proves that the Western world was able and willing to get into Rwanda, only to save its own citizens.

By April 10, Eastern Rwandan extremists implemented the second planned phase of killing, moving into the countryside. Young recruits of the *interahamwe* were told, across propagandist radio, that all Tutsis wanted power, would enslave the Hutu if they survived, and were invaders and spies of Rwanda. By April 15, the Tutsi Republican Front was quickly advancing toward the capital, Kigali; the Hutu killers accelerated the killings in attempts to "exterminate" the Tutsi race before the Front took over the capital. By April 21, two weeks after the start of the genocide, at least 100,000 Tutsis and Moderate Hutu were dead.

On that same day the Security Council of the United Nations, under pressure from Belgium and the United States, voted unanimously to remove all but 10% of its forces. Six full weeks after the genocide began, on May 17, the UN authorized 5000 peace keepers to Rwanda but with no timetable and therefore no required action; as no troops were "immediately available" from the 80 different governments approached, no action was taken.

The United States promised only 50 armoured cars, armoured cars that took over 5 months to arrive and never made it past Uganda. This was the extent of American support. By mid-May, 500,000 Rwandans were dead. By July 1994, after 100 days, the genocide ended after Tutsi Rebels recaptured the country. It is estimated that approximately 800,000 people died in the genocide (Ghosts of Rwanda). This massacre of innocent Rwandans happened five times faster than the Nazi massacres of World War II, and the "never again" Western world

remained silent (Triumph of Evil). Within ten weeks, one third of all Tutsis on earth were killed.

RWANDA GENOCIDE TIMELINE

1894	Germany colonizes Rwanda.
1918	The Belgians assume control of Rwanda.
1933	The Belgians organize a census and mandate that everyone be issued an identity card classifying them as either Tutsi, Hutu, or Twa.
December 9, 1948	The UN passes a resolution which both defines genocide and declares it a crime under international law.
1959	A Hutu rebellion begins against the Tutsis and Belgians.
January 1961	The Tutsi monarchy is abolished.
July 1, 1962	Rwanda gains its independence.
1973	Juvénal Habyarimana takes control of Rwanda in a bloodless coup.
1988	The RPF (Rwandan Patriotic Front) is created in Uganda.
1989	World coffee prices plummet. This significantly affects Rwanda's economy because coffee was one of its major cash crops.
1990	The RPF invade Rwanda, starting a civil war.
1991	A new constitution allows for multiple political parties.
July 8, 1993	RTLM (Radio Télévison des Milles Collines) begins broadcasting and spreading hate.
August 3, 1993	The Arusha Accords are agreed upon, opening government positions to both Hutu and Tutsi.
April 6, 1994	Rwandan President Juvénal Habyarimana is killed when his plane is shot out of the sky.
April 7, 1994	Hutu extremists begin killing their political opponents.
April 9, 1994	Massacre at Gikondo - hundreds of Tutsis are killed in the Pallottine Missionary Catholic Church. Since the killers were clearly targeting only Tutsi, the Gikondo massacre was the first clear sign that a genocide was occurring

April 15-16, 1994	Massacre at the Nyarubuye Roman Catholic Church - thousands of Tutsi are killed, first by grenades and guns and then by machetes and clubs.
April 18, 1994	The Kibuye Massacres. An estimated 12,000 Tutsis are killed after sheltering at the Gatwaro stadium in Gitesi. Another 50,000 are killed in the hills of Bisesero. More are killed in the town's hospital and church.
April 28-29, 1994	Approximately 250,000 people, mostly Tutsi, flee to neighbouring Tanzania.
May 23, 1994	The RPF takes control of the presidential palace.
July 5, 1994	The French establish a safe zone in the southwest corner of Rwanda.
July 13, 1994	Approximately one million people, mostly Hutu, begin fleeing to Zaire (now called the Democratic Republic of the Congo).
Mid-July 1994	The Rwanda Genocide ends when the RPF gains control of the country.

CURRENT SCENARIO

Recovery after the Rwandan genocide is still underway. The events of 1994 left Rwanda hollow as a country, and the slow recuperation, with the help of policy and international aid has seen Rwanda gradually restructure itself. Several post-genocide issues were dealt with by the subsequent President Paul Kagame who took seat in 2000.

One of the major issues Rwanda had to deal with was the justice system and the persons accused of the genocide who in large numbers were in the prisons. The *gacaca* system was adopted (community justice) which was used to quickly dispose of the cases.

Another major social issue was the remaking of the social fabric with the genocide as a living memory. At the end of the three months of genocide, the infrastructure was destroyed and the population was deeply traumatised. Schools, health centres, water and transport were in ruins. Families had been murdered, scattered, had been driven from their fields and were unable to feed themselves. It is in such a condition that Rwanda found itself in the wake of the events of 1994.

The new regime under Kagame has introduced policies to minimise ethnic divisions, and encourage economic development partnerships. He has taken a strong stand against corruption and given Rwandans hope and encouraged them to be more self-reliant.

However, the hatred which sparked the genocide is a living memory for most Rwandans, and maintaining social stability while allowing political openness is a complicated challenge for the government. Several human rights groups have criticised Kagame for restricting political freedom.

Several other aspects have to be seen while understanding the restructuring of Rwandan society. For a detailed study on the story of Rwandan restructuring and recovery, please refer to the following links:

http://www.rwandanstories.org/recovery/new_rwanda.html

http://www.rwandanstories.org/recovery/experiment_in_recovery.html

For testimonies of survivors and the specific problems faced by them, please refer to the following link:

http://www.un.org/en/preventgenocide/rwanda/education/survivortestimonies.shtml